



Charitable Giving: What Influences Donors' Choice Among Different Causes?

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Abstract While the literature is replete with studies that identify factors explaining why people are likely to make monetary contributions, less is known about which particular charitable causes they are likely to choose and how much they donate to them. This article examines donor choice among eight different causes using survey data collected in 2011 for a nationally representative sample in Austria. In particular, the study investigates the role of individual-level factors: subjective dispositions such as empathic concern, trust, and religiosity, and resources such as education and income. We find that subjective dispositions rather predict a donor's incidence of giving among causes but not the amount donated. Human resources, in contrast, are associated with both the incidence and the amount donated to particular causes, and they also mediate the impact of subjective dispositions. What is more, the study reveals that being asked to donate has the highest explanatory power regarding the incidence of giving among all causes investigated.

Keywords Charitable giving · Philanthropy · Donations · Donor choice · Solicitation · Resources · Personality traits

Introduction

Charitable giving is a ubiquitous global phenomenon (Wiepking and Handy 2015), and this naturally raises questions like: Why do people give away their money, and when they do, what influences their choice of what causes to support? While the extant literature is replete with studies that examine why people make contributions of money, less is known about the factors that predispose an individual's choice to the particular causes. The literature survey undertaken by Bekkers and Wiepking (2011), across various disciplines and methodologies, reveals eight mechanisms that explain donors' decisions to give. They include the awareness of need by the donor, being solicited for donations, and donors' reputational concerns and values (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). While these mechanisms may explain why individuals donate, they do not explain donors' choices among the various causes. For example, an individual might be motivated by his/her values to make a charitable donation; however, what influences the individual's choice among a plethora of causes seeking funds? In this paper, we examine this underexplored question using a nationally representative sample from Austria and investigate factors that are likely to predict which causes people donate to and the amount donated.

While this study primarily draws on literature that has identified mechanisms that predict charitable giving, it also includes studies that have established human resources and subjective dispositions—such as personality traits, attitudes and values—that may impact donations (Bekkers 2006; Einolf 2011; Wilson 2012). The principal focus of this

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research thus is on ‘donor choice,’ referring to both the incidence of giving and the amount donated using factors identified in the literature. It extends the current knowledge on donor choice in several ways. By utilizing a nationally representative data on donor choice, the amount donated to eight different causes and whether individuals had been solicited for each of the causes or not, we are able to address several limitations of previous studies. For example, existing studies examine giving to different organizations, or one or two causes, do not investigate the amount donated or do not use nationally representative samples. Moreover, we examine the influence of both individual resources and subjective dispositions and analyze the predictors in a stepwise approach, applying Heckman regression models to explore their differential impact and whether the effects of subjective dispositions are mediated by resources.

Review of the Literature on Donors’ Choice

We first examine the research addressing donors’ giving to various causes, followed by the literature on the determinants of donor choice. From this, we derive hypotheses related to (1) subjective dispositions and (2) resources.

Overview of Studies on Donor Choice

A large number of studies investigate the factors that affect giving among one or two types of charities in a single study. Most frequently, these studies analyze giving to secular and religious causes (e.g., Helms and Thornton 2012) or explore giving to international and national causes (e.g., Rajan et al. 2008). Other studies concentrate on a single cause (e.g., arts and culture, see Barnes 2011) or focus on a particular factors’ impact on donor choice, such as income (e.g., Breeze and Lloyd 2013; Ostrower 1997) or gender (e.g., Andreoni et al. 2003; Brown and Ferris 2007; Piper and Schnepf 2008; Rooney et al. 2007).

Few empirical studies investigate factors influencing donor choice between more than two causes in a single study. Among them is an article of Casale and Baumann (2015) employing data from the USA, the studies of Micklewright and Schnepf (2009), Sargeant et al. (2008), Kottasz (2004), and Bennett (2003), all of them referring to data from the UK, and the work of Wiepking (2010) and Srnka et al. (2003), both from continental Europe (see Table 1).

While all of them investigate determinants of donor choice across at least three causes, donor choice is often reduced to the incidence, while the amount donated is not considered, a serious limitation in the study of donor choice. Some of them solely examine donations for

particular organizations (e.g., Bennett 2003; Sargeant et al. 2008; Wiepking 2010) or do not use nationally representative samples (e.g., Srnka et al. 2003).

As mentioned above, we address these limitations in our study by examining the amount donated over eight different subsectors, looking at several determinants, such as donors’ subjective dispositions and resources. Furthermore, our research is conducted in a non-English-speaking country using a nationally representative sample, adding to the literature on donor choice, which for the most part has investigated English-speaking countries and non-representative samples.

Determinants of Donor Choice and Hypotheses

The large disciplinary and interdisciplinary literature on the determinants of prosocial behavior in general and giving in particular is surveyed in noteworthy exhaustive literature reviews by Bekkers and Wiepking (2011), Wiepking and Bekkers (2012b) and Wilson (2012). It finds that psychological theories tend to focus on subjective dispositions such as personality traits, attitudes, values, norms, self-concepts, and motivations in order to explain prosocial behavior, while sociological theories emphasize individual socio-demographic characteristics and human resources (Wilson 2012, p. 178). Scholars unanimously suggest to combine insights from various disciplines when studying the determinants of charitable behavior in order to generate new knowledge and not replicate findings from single disciplines (Wiepking and Bekkers 2012b).

Drawing on previous research that explored whether individual resources compensate or moderate subjective dispositions’ impact on charitable giving (Bekkers 2006; Einolf 2011), we include both resources and subjective dispositions to explain donor choice. We next present, based on the literature, how (1) subjective dispositions and (2) human resources affect donor choice. The term subjective disposition comprises a wide range of concepts, including personality traits, motives, attitudes, norms, and values which all refer ‘to the way people interpret themselves and the world around them’ (Wilson 2012, p. 179). In our study, the subjective dispositions used are generalized trust, empathic concern and religiosity. Human resources generally include the individual assets that may impact giving such as education and income.

Subjective Dispositions: Generalized Trust, Empathic Concern, and Religiosity

Generalized Trust

Individuals with higher levels of general trust are both more likely to donate and to give higher amounts compared

Table 1 Empirical literature investigating donor choice

Authors	Country	Sample	Dependent Variable(s)	Causes Investigated: Donor choice
Casale and Baumann (2015)	US	Nationally representative sample <i>n</i> = 4178	Incidence of giving	International and pooled Domestic issues (Religion, Youth development, Education, Health, Human services, Environment, Adult recreation, Arts, Public/societal benefit, Political, Private foundations)
Wiepking (2010)	NL	Nationally representative sample <i>n</i> = 1246 households	Incidence of giving	Sixty-four nonprofits (International, Faith-based, Children, Culture, Community/welfare services, Health/disability, Environment/animal protection) [investigated: organizations]
Micklewright and Schnepf (2009)	UK	Nationally representative sample <i>n</i> = 9050	Incidence and intensity of giving (Last 4 weeks)	International and Domestic causes, [Partial analyses for Animal welfare, Medical research, Children]
Sargeant et al. (2008)	UK	Donors from nine nonprofits <i>n</i> = 1255	Incidence of giving	Visual impairment, Animal welfare, Children [investigated: organizations]
Kottasz (2004)	UK	Non-random sample <i>n</i> = 217	Preference for giving (Conjoint analyses)	Animal welfare, Arts, Social services
Srnka et al. (2003)	Austria	One geographical region <i>n</i> = 264 (quota-sample)	Incidence of giving	Church Organizations, Social services, Health care, Emergency aid, Children's organizations, Environment/Animal protection, Refugee, Development Aid, Human rights
Bennett (2003)	UK	Non-random sample <i>n</i> = 250	Intensity of giving £100 (Forced choice)	Animal Welfare, Cancer research, Human rights [investigated: organizations]

to people with lower levels of general trust (Bekkers 2003a, p. 598). Moreover, the individual level of general trust influences the charity of choice (Brown and Ferris 2007; Wiepking 2010), since more trusting individuals are more likely to give to organizations where trust is required (Bekkers 2003a, p. 598). Philanthropic organizations depend on donors' trust, as donors cannot easily monitor the use of their donations (Bekkers 2003a, p. 596). For example, nonprofits that take on issues regarding international relief or environmental protection cannot easily be monitored by donors and require donor trust to elicit donations as their output may not be directly traced to their efforts or take place many years after. Thus, such nonprofits may likely attract donors that have higher levels of generalized trust (Wiepking 2010, p. 1085).

Hypothesis 1 Generalized trust is positively related to the incidence of giving and the amount donated for International Relief and Environmental Issues.

Empathic Concern

It is intuitively plausible that individuals who score higher on the empathic concern scale (i.e., responding to another person's situation with feelings that resemble the experience of the other) understand the needs of others better than those who do not score that high and thus are more likely to show prosocial behavior (Wiepking and Maas 2009; Wilson 2012). Indeed, empirical studies reveal that empathic concern is positively related to charitable giving (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011; Bennett 2003). Bekkers (2006), for instance, finds a positive relationship between empathic concern and generosity, with higher empathy related to higher total donations. The ability to empathize with others matters particularly when the beneficiaries are vulnerable and need some sort of protection (Webb and Khoo 2010, p. 2) or are suffering (Verhaert and Van den Poel 2011, p. 1293). This suggests that empathic donors are more likely to be attracted by causes that activate empathy such as international relief. Cheung and Chan (2000) found empathy to be related to the incidence of giving to international causes. Bennett (2003), in his study of donor

choice among three organizations, found that empathic concern was related to the incidence of giving for cancer care and animal welfare, but not human rights. Thus, on donor choice, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 2 Empathic concern is positively related to the incidence of giving and the amount donated for Domestic Relief, International Relief, Social Services, Health and Animal Welfare.

Religiosity

Individual level of religiosity, regardless of whether indicated by religious affiliation or religious service attendance, is a significant predictor of the likelihood and the level of giving (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). The mechanisms involved in this relationship differ for the two indicators of religiosity. Religious affiliated people give because they are taught it is their duty to help and because they may have stronger prosocial values compared to not religious affiliated individuals. People who regularly attend religious services are—in addition of having stronger prosocial values—more strongly involved in the religious community; they give because they face a stronger social norm on giving and higher levels of social pressure to conform to group standards (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). Moreover, religious service attendance brings people into opportunities to engage in promoting the collective good as they receive more solicitations (at religious service) to contribute to religious and secular causes the congregation supports (Brooks 2003; Brown and Ferris 2007). Empirical studies find religious affiliation and attendance at religious services positively related to religious giving and also secular giving (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). For example, Wiepking (2010) finds that religious organizations have an increased likelihood of receiving donations from religiously affiliated people, while Casale and Baumann (2015) find that religious attendance is a significant predictor of religious giving as well as giving to international causes. The latter is due to ‘*religious institutions taking up special collections for international programs*’ (p. 115). Taking account for the different mechanisms at work for religious affiliation and religious attendance, we formulate two hypotheses:

Hypothesis 3a Religious Affiliation is positively related to the incidence of giving and the amount donated for Religious Causes.

Hypothesis 3b Religious Attendance is positively related to the incidence of giving and the amount donated for Religious Causes and International Relief.

Human Resources: Education and Income

Education

The level of formal education is one of the main predictors of charitable giving, and it is positively related to the inclination to give and the amount donated (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). This is because of values, as education fosters prosocial motivation, and because education brings people into social networks, entailing higher levels of solicitations (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011; Brown and Ferris 2007). Also, it is argued that people with higher levels of education have higher cognitive abilities, which make them ‘*better able to understand*’ complex situations and therefore the needs of distant others (Wiepking and Maas 2009, p. 1977). In addition, higher levels of education are assumed to increase the degree of abstract thinking, which is necessary for making charitable donations to less concrete causes without quantifiable goals (Wiepking and Maas 2009, p. 1978), such as international relief or environmental issues. In other words, the awareness of need (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011) for rather distant and abstract causes is assumed to be more developed among people who have attained higher levels of formal education. Prior empirical research underpins these assumptions; it identifies a positive relation between higher educated donors and giving to international causes (Micklewright and Schnepf 2009; Rajan et al. 2008; Ribar and Wilhelm 1995). Srnka et al. (2003) in their bivariate analyses find education positively related to development aid, human rights, environment, and animal protection. We note that animal welfare includes both animal shelters as well as the protection of endangered wildlife, which is less proximate (elephants, for example) and likely to be abstract as compared to animal shelters. Based on these considerations, we thus hypothesize:

Hypothesis 4 Higher Education is positively related to the incidence of giving and the amount donated for International Relief, Animal Welfare, and Environmental Issues.

Income

While income is consistently identified as an important predictor of the amount donated, the results are mixed for the association between income and the incidence of giving; studies either find a positive or no relationship. As people with all levels of income are capable of making donations, those with higher income can afford to give more (Wiepking and Bekkers 2012a). With regard to donors’ choice, individuals with higher income may also

prefer to donate to different causes than those with lower incomes.

Due to their life-experience, wealthy people and poor people ‘*might have different perspectives of the issues that are most deserving assistance*’ (Bennett 2012, p. 873). As individuals with lower incomes are closer to social problems such as bad housing, vulnerability to crime, or low-quality medical care, they are said to be particularly more aware of social needs of others (Bennett 2012). Others argue that giving provides an opportunity to express personal taste, passion, personal interest and is an act of self-actualization (Bennett 2003; Ostrower 1997; Radley and Kennedy 1995). Donors thus give to causes which relate to their personal taste and also care about the cause’s reputation (Breeze and Lloyd 2013; Kottasz 2004). Breeze and Lloyd (2013), Banks and Tanner (1999), and Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007) show that affluent people predominately give to arts and culture and higher education in the UK. According to Kottasz (2004), high-earning professional males are attracted to giving to arts and cultural charities, particularly well-established organizations from which they can then receive invitations to special events and are likely to be solicited. Similar results were found by Ostrower (1997), who investigated elite giving. Furthermore, qualitative studies provide evidence that wealthy people are more likely to donate to arts and culture, education, health, and medical research, but not that frequently to environmental causes, religious organizations, and overseas development (Lloyd 2004, p. 2). Following the reasoning above, we thus hypothesize:

Hypothesis 5 Income is positively related to the incidence of giving and the amount donated for Culture and Education.

Data, Measures, and Method

This study employs data derived from a research project using a stratified multistage design and face-to-face interviews of 1011 Austrian adults aged 15 years and older. The sample is nationally representative, and the data were collected in the fall of 2011 with questions probing individuals’ giving behavior in the previous 12 months.

To avoid recall bias associated with donations made in the previous 12 months, the survey included several recall cues in the form of two separate modules. Module 1 asks the individual to recall whether they have made donations using one of the different methods listed (e.g., door-to-door, online, etc.) and if yes, the amount donated; module 2 asks if an individual has made donations to any one the causes listed (e.g., international relief, animal welfare, etc.), and if yes, how much.

Using these longer modules results in more accurate data as people are better in recollecting their actual donations when cues (such as method used or cause for the solicitation) are given (Bekkers and Wiepking 2006), thereby avoiding the recall bias of shorter surveys (Hall 2001; Kirsch et al. 2001; Rooney et al. 2004; Wilhelm 2007). The responses provided detailed data that included information on the amount donated for each of the eight listed causes. In addition, the survey measured individual-level variables beyond socio-demographics, such as levels of generalized trust, income, religiosity, community type, and volunteering behavior.

Dependent Variables

The dependent variable in the first part of our analysis is the intensity of giving in the previous 12 months: a continuous variable in the form of the log of the total amount donated by an individual. In the second part of our analyses, we investigate eight dependent variables; the log of the amount donated to each of the following causes: Animal Welfare, Environmental Issues, International Relief, Domestic Relief, Social Services, Health, Religious Causes, and Culture and Education. In the descriptive statistics in Table 2, we report on the donations made to each particular cause, and note that more than half of the sample (54.9%) made a donation (i.e., to any cause).

Independent Variables

The predictor variables we use to test our hypotheses refer to individuals’ human resources and subjective dispositions. Human resources are the level of formal education and income. Education is measured by three categorical variables. The initial level (≤ 9 years of formal education)

Table 2 Descriptive statistics on dependent variables

Dep. variables	Amount (Euro)		
	Mean	Median	SD
Total donations	98.807	35.500	263.547
Animal Welfare	58.713	20.000	243.522
Environmental Issues	53.375	25.000	63.401
International Relief	58.961	50.000	57.975
Domestic Relief	26.099	20.000	31.573
Social Services	64.983	25.000	171.390
Health	130.734	25.000	670.218
Religious Causes	48.424	20.000	160.830
Culture and Education	209.621	20.000	922.467

$n = 1011$; the research design allowed people to indicate giving to multiple causes

Table 3 Descriptive statistics on independent variables

Independent variables	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Age less than 30 (cat. reference)	0.176	0.381	0.00	1.00
Age between 30 and 64	0.572	0.495	0.00	1.00
Age more than 64	0.252	0.435	0.00	1.00
Gender (female = 1)	0.574	0.495	0.00	1.00
Marital status (married = 1)	0.477	0.500	0.00	1.00
Children in household (yes = 1)	0.157	0.364	0.00	1.00
Community type (rural = 1; urban = 0)	0.676	0.468	0.00	1.00
Generalized trust	2.797	0.889	1.00	5.00
Empathic concern	3.349	0.937	1.00	5.00
Religious affiliation (yes = 1)	0.806	0.396	0.00	1.00
Religious attendance (never = 1; often = 4)	2.110	1.040	1.00	4.00
Level of education 1 (cat. reference)	0.196	0.397	0.00	1.00
Level of education 2	0.579	0.494	0.00	1.00
Level of education 3	0.226	0.418	0.00	1.00
Ln of income	6.773	1.470	0.00	8.41
Volunteering (yes = 1)	0.173	0.379	0.00	1.00
Solicited for any cause (yes = 1)	0.575	0.495	0.00	1.00

N = 1011

serves as reference category followed by the second category (10–12 years of formal education) and third category (>12 years of formal education). Income is measured by the natural logarithm of respondents' annual income.

Subjective dispositions measured in the survey include: generalized trust, empathic concern as well as religious affiliation and attendance. The degree of generalized trust is measured using three items on a five-point Likert scale developed by Rosenberg (1956) and modified by Bekkers (2003a). The items are: 'In general, most people can be trusted,' 'You cannot be too careful in dealing with other people,' (reverse coded) and 'Most people would tell a lie if they could gain by it' (reverse coded). The trust variable was computed as the mean of these items (Cronbach's alpha = 0.790).

Empathic Concern levels measured by four items on a five-point Likert scale, developed by Davis (1994) are: 'I often feel concern for people who are less fortunate materially than me,' 'Other people's problems don't usually bother me' (reverse coded), 'I am often touched by what other people go through,' and 'Other people's misfortune does not usually bother me' (reverse coded) (cf. Bekkers 2004; Davis 1994). Empathic Concern was calculated as the mean of these items (Cronbach's alpha = 0.704).¹

Religious Affiliation is measured by a dummy variable indicating self-identified religious affiliation (such as Roman Catholic and Protestant); and Religious Attendance

was measured using a scale with response ranging from 1 (=never attending) to 4 (=attending often) (Table 3).

Our control variables are socio-demographics that are found to influence charitable giving in the literature. We include a dummy variable for gender (female = 1) and measure age by three categories with a dummy variable for each of them. Dummy variables for age are used as the relationship between age (in years) and giving may be nonlinear. In other words, age might be related to giving only when it is above a certain threshold (cf. Bekkers 2003b, p. 608). The three categories used are: greater than 64 years old, between 30 and 64 years, and less than 30 years old, which is the reference category.²

We also control for marital status with a dummy variable for individuals who are 'married or cohabitating,' as opposed to single, divorced and not-cohabiting, and widowed people. This controls for the belief that individuals with more extended social networks are more often solicited for donations (Wiepking and Maas 2009, p. 1976). Similarly, we include a dummy variable indicating whether the respondents live in a household with at least one child younger than 14 years or whether the individual has done volunteer work (dummy variable) in the previous 12 months, to control for extended social networks that may influence charitable giving and solicitations. Moreover, we control for the type of community in which donors

¹ Responses were factor analyzed; one-dimensional solutions emerged in both Generalized Trust and Empathic Concern.

² Empirically, there is evidence that giving might increase until people retire (this is at about 65 in Austria), but decreases afterward, at least for those who have low levels of income (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011).

reside; individuals in rural environments are significantly more likely to donate as compared to individuals in urban environments (AFP 2010) due to a greater sense of reciprocity and higher social pressure due to increased likelihood of face-to face contacts, and making non-compliance with social norms easily detected (Bekkers 2005, 2006, p. 350). The Community Type variable was measured by a dummy variable = 1 if living in a community with less than 50,000 inhabitants, and 0 = if living in a community with more than 50,000 inhabitants.

Our final control is a dummy variable which refers to ‘Being Asked,’ since the majority of donations occur in response to a solicitation (Andreoni and Payne 2003; Bryant et al. 2003). Being asked makes the donor aware of the need, exerts social pressure and also presents an opportunity to donate (Wang and Graddy 2008). In the first part of our analysis, the dummy variable ‘Being Asked’ refers to any cause. In the second part of the analysis, the dummy refers to giving to different causes and is the responses to the eight questions in the survey: ‘In the last 12 months, have you been personally asked for donating money to the following causes?’ With a list of causes provided: Animal Welfare; Health; etc.

Method

For our analytical strategy, we utilize Heckman’s two-stage regression models (Heckman 1979) to investigate factors that influence donor behavior. This is done as the decision to donate precedes the amount donated, and this prior decision may be influenced by different factors than the secondary decision on the amount given (Forbes and Zampelli 2011, p. 1149). The Heckman two-stage regression model estimates the first selection (to donate or not) with a probit and incorporates the results of the first-stage selection in the second-stage decision (amount donated) (Forbes and Zampelli 2011, p. 1149). We conduct our analysis with Stata/SE 14.1.

In order to test the hypotheses of this study, for each of the eight charitable causes we present three Heckman regression models.³ The first model (Model I for each cause) includes our controls for age, gender, children, marital status, and the four predictor variables on subjective dispositions: level of Generalized Trust, Empathic Concern, Religious Affiliation, and Religious Attendance. In the second model (Model II), we add our predictors on human resources, i.e., Education and Income. In the final model (Model III for each cause), we add the variables on solicitation and volunteering.

The stepwise approach allows us to examine the impact of subjective dispositions and human resources sequentially and to see whether the effects of the predictor variables stay robust when adding the controls for solicitation and volunteering. By introducing subjective dispositions before human resources in our regressions, we are able to test whether effects of subjective dispositions are mediated by resources, following Bekkers (2005). We employ the same regressors in the first (selection) and in the second (outcome) equation of the Heckman model, except for the variable on an individuals’ community type, which is excluded in the second-stage regression as this variable has a stronger influence on the incidence and not intensity to donate (AFP 2010).

In order to compare the effect sizes of the various predictors, variables were Z-standardized before running regression analyses. Our analysis on total giving refers to the full sample; all subsequent analyses on donor choice are based on donors only, i.e., individuals who have donated to at least one cause.

Findings

In this section, we first describe the findings on the factors that influence total giving, both on the decision to give and the amount donated. Subsequently, we report the results on the factors that influence donor choice for the different causes and make reference to the relevant hypotheses with respect to our findings.

Results on Total Giving

Table 4 exhibits the coefficients of the Heckman two-stage regression on individuals’ amount donated. We find that all subjective dispositions predictors: Generalized Trust, Empathic Concern, Religious Affiliation, and Religious Attendance are positively and significantly related to the incidence to donate. Empathic Concern and Religious Attendance are also positively related to the amount donated, while Religious Affiliation and the amount donated are negatively associated. Human resources, Education and Income, are not associated with the decision to donate in our data; however, Education is related positively to the amount donated: People who have attained twelve or more years of education are more generous compared to those with fewer years of education.

The opposite is true for being solicited, which is positively and significantly associated with the decision to donate, but not with the amount donated. Older individuals, those who are married/cohabitated and those who volunteer—compared to their respective counterparts, are more likely to make a donation, while age and volunteering are

³ Multinomial regression analyses are not applicable because the research design allowed respondents to indicate giving to multiple causes.

Table 4 Donations to all causes (Heckman two-stage regression analyses)

	Selection (of giving) Coefficients	Amount of total donations Coefficients
Age 30–64	0.162*	0.282**
Age <64	0.332***	0.426**
Gender (female = 1)	0.077	0.042
Married	0.145**	0.074
Children	−0.085(+)	−0.092
Community type (rural = 1)	0.009	−
Generalized trust	0.104*	0.078
Empathic concern	0.199***	0.171*
Religious affiliation	0.113*	−0.183*
Religious attendance	0.144**	0.191*
Level of education 2	0.073	0.071
Level of education 3	0.093	0.447***
ln of income	−0.025	0.065
Volunteering	0.152	0.125*
Solicited for any cause	0.750	−0.014
Constant	0.153	3.426***

$N = 1011$ 447 censored observations; Dependent variable in outcome equation: ln of the amount donated; Coefficients base on z-standardized data; Wald $\chi^2 = 142.37$; Levels of significance: *** $p \leq 0.01$; ** $p \leq 0.05$; * $p \leq 0.10$; (+) $p \leq 0.10$

also positively associated with the amount donated. Examining the coefficients, we note that solicitation has the greatest association on whether a person has donated or not while the level of formal Education (twelve or more years) has the greatest impact on the total amount donated. Age, particularly being older than 64 years, has the second-strongest impact both on the decision to give and the amount given. Control variables that are unrelated to individual giving behavior are: gender, having children, and the community type in which people reside.

Results on Donor Choice

Our findings on donors' choice, expressed by the incidence of giving and the amount donated to the eight different causes are exhibited in Tables 5a–d. Using a stepwise approach, we identify predictors that are significant on the 0.05-level in the three models (Model I, Model II and Model III) and focus on those that remain significant in Model II. For each predictor, we present our findings and relate them to the hypotheses proposed. The results on our hypotheses are summarized in Table 6.

Subjective Dispositions: Our findings for subjective dispositions vary by cause as expected but not always in the ways hypothesized. We find subjective dispositions more likely to influence the decision to give but not the amount given with a few exceptions. Generalized Trust is positively associated with the decision to give and the amount given to Religious Causes, but negatively

associated with the decision to give to Domestic Relief. Thus, *Hypothesis 1* is partially supported, as we find as expected a positive relationship between higher levels of Generalized Trust with International Relief but not with Environmental Issues—causes that are hard to evaluate or observe for the donor as compared to other causes.

Our findings regarding Empathic Concern show partial support for *Hypothesis 2*. Donors higher on the empathic concern scale are more likely to give to International Relief, Social Services and Health in Models II, however, not for Domestic Relief and Animal Welfare. Remarkably, Empathic Concern, the ability of putting oneself in somebody's shoes, influences the decision to give to particular causes but does not influence the amount donated to these causes, which suggests empathic individuals want to do something, but not much; we refer to this as the 'low-cost' solution, that we expand on later.

Religious Affiliation is not a predictor for giving to religious causes lending no support to *Hypothesis 3a*. Interestingly, it is negatively related to giving to Social Services and Environmental Issues, implying religiously affiliated donors being less likely to give toward these two causes. With respect to Religious Attendance, as expected there is a positive and significant relation with giving to Religious Causes, both for incidence and intensity but no support for International Relief, contrary to our expectations. Also, we find a significant and positive association with the decision to give to Social Services but negatively with giving to Health, Animal Welfare, and Culture and

Table 5 Donations given by Cause (Heckman two-stage regressions)

	Animal Welfare			Environmental Issues		
	Model I	Model II	Model III	Model I	Model II	Model III
(a)						
Outcome Model						
Age 30–64	0.023	0.231	0.289	0.062	0.104	0.118
Age <64	0.101	0.295	0.498	0.762 (+)	0.865	0.934
Gender (female = 1)	0.999	0.462	0.404	−0.484	−0.651	−0.654
Married	−0.660	−0.276	−0.398	0.239	0.256	0.295
Children	−0.594	−0.249	−0.295	0.071	0.054	−0.028
Generalized trust	0.474	0.037	0.064	−0.598(+)	−0.622	−0.406
Empathic concern	0.294	0.086	0.168	0.011	−0.013	−0.227
Religious affiliation	−0.276	−0.143	0.044	0.288	0.418	0.438
Religious attendance	−1.314	−0.259	−0.293	−0.033	−0.148	−0.268
Level of education 2		0.203	0.234		−0.132	0.006
Level of education 3		0.673*	0.534 (+)		−0.411	0.047
ln of income		0.055	0.046		−0.148	−0.139
Volunteering			−0.034			−0.379
Solicitation			1.178			−1.297
Constant	−8.606	−0.624	−1.369	7.876**	9.504 (+)	10.328
Selection Model						
Age 30–64	−0.015	0.028	0.059	−0.137	−0.091	−0.094
Age <64	−0.004	0.035	0.144	−0.277*	−0.204	−0.204
Gender (female = 1)	0.148*	0.172*	0.138 (+)	0.139	0.168 (+)	0.188 (+)
Married	−0.107	−0.109	−0.171*	−0.062	−0.066	−0.079
Children	−0.086	−0.098	−0.114	−0.009	−0.024	0.007
Community type (rural = 1)	0.057	0.129 (+)	0.135 (+)	−0.222**	−0.157 (+)	−0.044
Generalized trust	0.084	0.055	0.061	0.118	0.088	0.028
Empathic concern	0.048	0.042	0.093	0.057	0.056	0.162
Religious affiliation	−0.024	−0.019	0.077	−0.224**	−0.219**	−0.221*
Religious attendance	−0.233**	−0.212 **	−0.237**	0.052	0.089	0.129
Level of education 2		−0.044	−0.027		0.157	0.160
Level of education 3		0.172 (+)	0.098		0.307*	0.204
ln of income		0.039	0.025		0.007	0.027
Volunteering			−0.007			0.128
Solicitation			0.563***			0.544***
Constant	−0.903***	−0.920***	−1.056***	−1.594***	−1.626***	−1.897***
	International Relief			Domestic Relief		
	Model I	Model II	Model III	Model I	Model II	Model III
(b)						
Outcome Model						
Age 30–64	−0.132	−0.172	−0.501	0.216	0.083	−0.040
Age <64	−0.251	−0.302	−0.735	0.286	0.221	0.099
Gender (female = 1)	0.007	0.056	−0.051	−0.216	−0.103	−0.068
Married	0.097	0.071	0.098	0.193	0.194*	0.167*
Children	−0.072	−0.093	−0.194	−0.039	−0.049	−0.075
Generalized trust	−0.030	−0.015	−0.112	−0.180	−0.146	−0.099
Empathic concern	−0.180	−0.140	−0.383	0.126	0.122(+)	0.121(+)
Religious affiliation	−0.016	−0.037	−0.166	0.137	0.140	0.116

Table 5 continued

	International Relief			Domestic Relief		
	Model I	Model II	Model III	Model I	Model II	Model III
Religious attendance	−0.144	−0.094	−0.099	0.017	0.042	0.034
Level of education 2		0.051	0.004		0.132	0.118
Level of education 3		0.133	0.063		0.239*	0.231*
ln of income		0.071	0.150		0.148	0.099
Volunteering			0.123			0.077
Solicitation			−0.966			0.088
Constant	5.203***	4.978***	6.886**	1.608	2.026**	2.492**
Selection Model						
Age 30–64	0.243*	0.342**	0.370**	0.308	0.290*	0.151
Age <64	0.314**	0.408**	0.473**	0.266	0.236(+)	0.147
Gender (female = 1)	−0.004	−0.005	0.061	−0.129	−0.103	−0.126(+)
Married	0.016	−0.004	−0.030	0.054	0.069	−0.001
Children	0.013	−0.011	0.053	0.063	0.073	0.173*
Community type (rural = 1)	−0.289***	−0.221**	−0.125(+)	0.181	0.203**	0.194*
Generalized trust	0.164*	0.130*	0.128(+)	−0.190	−0.195**	−0.135(+)
Empathic concern	0.264***	0.266***	0.295***	−0.017	−0.020	0.051
Religious affiliation	0.024	0.036	0.087	0.144	0.144(+)	0.080
Religious attendance	0.122	0.135(+)	0.076	−0.055	−0.037	−0.071
Level of education 2		−0.020	−0.026		−0.061	−0.069
Level of education 3		0.241**	0.158		−0.003	−0.062
ln of income		−0.090	−0.069		0.156*	0.214*
Volunteering			0.005			0.043
Solicitation			0.544***			0.871***
Constant	−0.806***	−0.830***	−0.923***	−0.714	−0.722***	−0.923***
	Social Services			Health		
	Model I	Model II	Model III	Model I	Model II	Model III
(c)						
Outcome Model						
Age 30–64	0.208	0.246	0.260	0.030	0.078	0.251
Age <64	0.422*	0.453*	0.484*	−0.453	−0.607	0.238
Gender (female = 1)	−0.106	−0.092	−0.085	−0.455	−0.756	−0.199
Married	0.130	0.134	0.142	−0.246	−0.449	0.041
Children	−0.062	−0.069	0.001	0.114	0.150	−0.045
Generalized trust	0.098	0.098	0.116	−0.008	−0.007	−0.023
Empathic concern	−0.071	−0.058	−0.205	−0.571	−0.749	−0.179
Religious affiliation	0.157	0.131	0.176	0.052	0.096	−0.122
Religious attendance	−0.204(+)	−0.167	−0.286	0.736	0.782	0.279
Level of education 2		0.077	−0.008		−0.221	0.040
Level of education 3		0.120	0.064		−0.109	0.209
ln of income		0.003	−0.035		−0.929	−0.319
Volunteering			0.124			0.341
Solicitation			−0.509			−0.552
Constant	4.500***	4.308***	5.470***	10.068	11.790	5.947
Selection Model						
Age 30–64	0.140	0.139	0.094	0.055	0.035	0.023
Age <64	0.095	0.112	0.073	0.235*	0.230*	0.224(+)

Table 5 continued

	Social Services			Health		
	Model I	Model II	Model III	Model I	Model II	Model III
Gender (female = 1)	0.024	0.045	0.026	0.125(+)	0.167*	0.203**
Married	−0.010	−0.011	0.006	0.143*	0.158*	0.165*
Children	−0.082	−0.082	−0.114(+)	−0.082	−0.075	−0.107
Community type (rural = 1)	−0.217***	−0.192**	−0.095	−0.068	−0.050	0.011
Generalized trust	0.062	0.053	0.009	0.011	0.011	0.030
Empathic concern	0.140*	0.142*	0.202**	0.181**	0.189**	0.244**
Religious affiliation	−0.148*	−0.147*	−0.094	−0.005	−0.013	0.069
Religious attendance	0.151*	0.168*	0.137(+)	−0.188*	−0.164*	−0.208*
Level of education 2		0.104	0.114		0.075	0.126
Level of education 3		0.131	0.099		0.052	0.062
ln of income		0.032	0.047		0.188(+)	0.136
Volunteering			−0.051			−0.107
Solicitation			0.493***			0.502***
Constant	−0.506***	−0.510***	−0.532***	−0.911***	−0.929***	−1.034***
	Religious Causes			Culture/Education		
	Model I	Model II	Model III	Model I	Model II	Model III
(d)						
Outcome Model						
Age 30–64	0.068	0.143	0.176	0.032	0.768	0.610
Age <64	0.189	0.291*	0.330**			
Gender (female = 1)	−0.048	−0.009	0.000	−0.376	−0.136	−0.210
Married	0.020	−0.011	−0.020	−0.034	0.333	0.286
Children	−0.115	−0.136(+)	−0.143*	0.077	0.436(+)	0.489
Generalized trust	0.237**	0.230**	0.229***	0.068	0.234	0.140
Empathic concern	0.041	0.066	0.070	0.334	0.139	0.201
Religious affiliation	0.188	0.148	0.071	−0.049	0.218	0.426
Religious attendance	0.599*	0.383	0.300*	0.241	−0.147	−0.250
Level of education 2		0.093	0.076		0.088	−0.140
Level of education 3		0.297*	0.309**		0.525	0.286
ln of income		−0.084	−0.108		0.273	0.276
Volunteering			0.063			0.236
Solicitation			−0.014			0.334
Constant	2.025*	2.727**	3.004***	6.312	0.737	0.736
Selection Model						
Age 30–64	−0.074	−0.098	−0.071	0.308*	0.356**	0.586*
Age <64	−0.083	−0.120	0.001			
Gender (female = 1)	−0.088	−0.084	−0.080	0.090	0.144	0.168
Married	−0.001	0.011	0.008	0.143	0.166	0.213
Children	0.004	0.016	0.074	0.100	0.093	0.126
Community type (rural = 1)	0.166**	0.152	0.224**	−0.007	0.102	0.270
Generalized trust	−0.073	−0.062	−0.070	0.044	0.001	−0.024
Empathic concern	−0.074	−0.074	0.002	0.103	0.106	0.408*
Religious affiliation	0.159*	0.154(+)	0.087	0.105	0.110	0.171
Religious attendance	0.495***	0.503***	0.366***	−0.220*	−0.200(+)	−0.342*
Level of education 2		−0.062	0.003		−0.008	0.014
Level of education 3		−0.109	−0.027		0.269(+)	0.277

Table 5 continued

	Religious Causes			Culture/Education		
	Model I	Model II	Model III	Model I	Model II	Model III
ln of income		0.086	0.106		0.095	0.147
Volunteering			0.160*			0.365**
Solicitation			0.821***			0.722***
Constant	−0.489***	−0.494***	−0.588***	−1.737***	−1.810***	−2.713***

$N = 545$ (Donors only); Dependent variable in outcome equation: ln of the amount donated; coefficients base on z-standardized data; Levels of significance: *** $p \leq 0.01$; ** $p \leq 0.05$; * $p \leq 0.10$; (+) $p \leq 0.10$

Table 6 Findings on hypotheses

Hypotheses	Expected relation	Results	
		Decision to give	Amount given
H1. Generalized Trust	+ International Relief	Supported	Not supported
	+ Environmental Issues	Not supported	Not supported
H2. Empathic Concern	+ Domestic Relief	Not supported	Not supported
	+ International Relief	Supported	Not supported
	+ Social Services	Supported	Not supported
	+ Health	Supported	Not supported
	+ Animal Welfare	Not Supported	Not Supported
H3a. Religious Affiliation	+ Religious Causes	Not Supported	Not supported
3b. Religious Attendance	+ Religious Causes	Supported	Supported
	+ International Relief	Not Supported	Not supported
H4. Higher Education	+ International Relief	Supported	Not supported
	+ Environmental Issues	Supported	Not supported
	+ Animal Welfare	Not supported	Supported
H5. Income	+ Culture and Education	Not supported	Not supported

Education (the latter significant on the 0.1-level in Model II). Results do not support *Hypothesis 3a*, but lend partial support to *Hypothesis 3b*.

Human resources: Our data lend partial support for *Hypothesis 4* that Education is an important predictor for donor choice with regard to giving. Education is positively associated with the decision to give to Environmental Issues and International Relief. In addition, donors having attained twelve or more years of formal education give higher amounts to Animal Welfare, to Domestic Relief and to Religious Causes. Hypothesis 4, suggesting the level of Education associated with giving to Environmental Issues, International Relief and Animal Welfare, is partially supported. The effect on Environmental Issues and International Relief, however, disappears as further predictors on solicitation and volunteering are added in Model III, giving reason to assume that people with higher levels of education also are likely to volunteer and thus solicited. Income positively influences the decision to give to Domestic

Relief. *Hypothesis 5*, which states that income is positively related to Arts and Culture, is not supported by our data.

Discussion

What factors determine which causes donors choose to support: donors' subjective dispositions or their human resources? In particular, we examined whether donors' inclination to give to charitable causes and the amount donated to these causes can be predicted by their subjective dispositions or their resources. While prior studies had investigated donors' choice among organizations, few have examined more than two causes, and often focusing on the likelihood of giving and not the amount donated. These limitations were addressed in this study by investigating eight subsectors. Based on the literature review, we developed five hypotheses on donor choice for particular causes that we tested on our nationally random sample

using Heckman two-stage regressions. We find partial support for our hypotheses (see Table 6) as related to Generalized Trust, Empathic Concern, Religious Attendance, and Education and no support for Religious Affiliation and Income.

Donor's subjective dispositions generally influence the choice for a particular cause, but not the amount donated to a cause. For instance, Empathic Concern is associated with giving to International Relief, Social Services, and Health, but not with the amount donated to these causes. We relate this to the literature that individual attitudes and values tend to predict behaviors that incur low material costs, but not when substantial costs are involved, referred to as the low-cost hypothesis (Neuberg et al. 1997). This low-cost hypothesis may well explain our results: While subjective dispositions are useful to predict who is more likely to take out their wallets to donate, they cannot predict how much they donate. Giving small amounts of money is a low-cost measure that easily alleviates the social pressure of the 'ask' while giving higher amounts is costly to the donor, therefore not undertaken. Further research on the alignment of the cause of the solicitation and the donor's values need to be made to understand who is willing to undertake a high-cost measure of donating generously.

In contrast to subjective dispositions, human resources are associated with both, donors' decisions to give and the amount donated to particular causes in our study. This general pattern is also supported by non-hypothesized relationships that turned out to be significant, showing Education positively associated with the amount donated to Domestic Relief and Religious Causes, and Income positively related to giving to Domestic Relief (see Table 7). We also found that effects of subjective dispositions are mediated by human resources, as slightly significant effects

(on the 0.1-level) of Generalized Trust and Religiosity on the amount donated found in Model I disappear in Model II when human resources are added. This is the case for associations between Generalized Trust and Environmental Issues (an association suggested in Hypothesis 1) and for associations between Religious Attendance and both Social Services and Religious Causes (the latter refers to Hypothesis 3b). These results are in line with Bekkers (2006, p. 358) who found the effects of resources on philanthropy—in his study measured by the incidence—stronger than those of personality characteristics; he also noted that levels of empathic concerns on donors generosity are mediated by verbal proficiency, which he defines as an indicator of human capital.

Regarding the hypotheses on human resources, we find support for the assumption that the ability of abstract thinking is necessary for giving to less concrete causes without quantifiable goals, as discussed earlier (Cheung and Chan 2000; Wiepking and Maas 2009). While higher levels of Education are associated with giving to Environmental Issues and International Relief, we find Education also positively associated with the amount donated to Animal Welfare. Thus, the level of Education is a meaningful predictor for all three causes.

Income is not associated with donors' decision to give to Arts and Education; this does not support our hypothesis and contradicts findings in the literature. Our hypothesis builds on literature based on research on Anglo-Saxon countries where the funding for higher education and arts and culture traditionally depend on private giving, whereas in Austria the situation is much different: Higher education is offered (almost) for free and paid for by tax revenues; and arts and culture organizations are also funded by public sources to a large extent. For example, funding comes from

Table 7 Findings on unexpected relations

Subjective Dispositions/ Human Resources	Causes	Results	
		Decision to give	Amount given
Generalized Trust	Domestic Relief	Negatively related	Positively related
	Religious Causes		
Empathic Concern	Culture and Education	Positively related	
Religious Affiliation	Environmental Issues	Negatively related	
	Social Services	Negatively related	
Religious Attendance	Culture and Education	Negatively related	
	Social Services	Positively related	
	Health	Negatively related	
	Animal Welfare	Negatively related	
Higher Education	Domestic Relief		Positively related
	Religious Causes		Positively related
Income	Domestic Relief	Positively related	

the public sector for Culture (33%) and Education (73%) in Austria, as compared 7% and 20%, respectively, in the USA (Salamon and Sokolowski 2004). Therefore, giving to Art and Education, which is common practice among affluent individuals in the USA or UK, is not prevalent in the Austrian context. In contrast, we found individuals with higher levels of income more likely to give to Domestic Relief (see Table 7). As local fire brigades are included in this cause and they often use door-to-door solicitations, it could be that the social pressure to give is higher for more affluent people.

Testing hypotheses on individuals' subjective dispositions revealed that higher levels of Generalized Trust are indeed necessary for making donations to causes where the impact is often physically distant and harder to measure. Our study supports this assumption for International Relief, and in part replicates Wiepking (2010), who finds individuals with confidence in nonprofits more likely to donate to International Relief. A finding not hypothesized is that Generalized Trust is negatively related to giving to Domestic Relief, underpinning our argument that individuals with lower levels of trust prefer to monitor what happens with their donation, and this might be easier for donations to Domestic than International Relief.

The hypothesis that suggests a positive relation between Religious Affiliation and giving to Religious Causes is not supported. This finding is at the odds with results from a large body of empirical work on this topic (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011). We also note that results on total giving (Table 4) show that Religious Affiliation is positively and significantly associated with the decision to give, but negatively and significantly with the total amount donated. Thus, religiously affiliated donors in Austria are more likely to give, but may not feel the need to support religious causes (Table 5d). Indeed, as religiously affiliated individuals have to pay an obligatory church membership fee to maintain their affiliation in Austria, they may not face any social pressure or even be aware of the religious causes, unless they attend church services to donate to Religious Causes. Thus, not surprisingly, Religious Attendance is positively related to donor choice to Religious Causes as it results in social pressure and awareness of religious causes that need support as well as many collections for donations take place during Roman Catholic services;⁴ there is the ease and opportunity of making a donation (Bekkers and Wiepking 2011).

The same mechanisms—solicitations in church and social pressure—we hypothesized would explain why Religious Attendance influences donor choice of International Relief; however, this relationship was not supported.

This may be because prompts in the survey for International Relief did not include development aid, which is often a target for collections at places of worship. In contrast, Religious Attendance turned out to be positively related to the incidence of giving to Social Services (see Table 7). This might be explained by the fact that collections during or after religious services sometimes indeed target social issues such as homeless people or refugees in Austria.

With regard to other relationships that turned out to be significant, for example the negative association between Religious Affiliation and Environmental Issues and Religious Attendance and Animal Welfare, we can only speculate about the mechanisms at work. A guess would be that (Roman Catholic) religious people are rather conservative and most of them also affiliated with one of the conservative political parties in Austria, while animal and environmental protection is mainly an issue of those political parties they are not affiliated with.

Some of the socio-demographic controls were significant for the model explaining donor choice. For example, age to the incidence of giving to International Relief, Domestic Relief, Health, and Arts and Education. Also, Age is negatively related to giving to Environmental Issues. Female donors are more inclined to give to Animal Welfare, replicating a finding of Srnka et al. (2003), while married/cohabited donors and female donors are more inclined to choose Health-related causes. Volunteering donors are more likely to give to Religious Causes and Culture and Education compared to those not volunteering. With respect to donor choice and the amount donated, older individuals are more likely to donate larger amounts to Social Services and Religious Causes, while married/cohabited donors are more inclined to give higher amounts to International Relief compared to their counterparts.

Being solicited for a particular cause is influential across all causes. It is a significant predictor with regard to the decision to give for a cause; however, solicitation is not associated with the amount given for any of the causes investigated. We find this result in line with the argument that asking for donations provides the donor an opportunity to donate as well as exerts some social pressure to donate (Meer and Rosen 2011). Yet, what it does not seem to do is to make the donor to give higher amounts—compared to donors not solicited. When comparing the coefficients in the regression models (which our analyses allow for because of z-standardized data), we find that solicitation has the strongest influence on donor decision to give for all of the eight causes investigated. This contributes to the literature on charitable giving, which often looks to individual-level characteristics to explain donations separately and does not compare it with other predictors, and it

⁴ The Roman-Catholic denomination is the far most populous denomination in Austria.

substantiates Bekkers and Wiepking (2011) who identified solicitation as a primary mechanism of giving. When introducing solicitation into the model, its effect eliminated the effects of some other individual-level characteristics such as Education or Age, which are related to donor choice in other studies that do not control for solicitation. Yet, almost all hypothesized findings of the predictor variables of this study remain the same when solicitation is added in Model III.

Conclusion

This research is among the first few studies—following Wiepking’s (2010) research based in the Netherlands that investigates the factors that impact donors’ choice in continental Europe. Our study builds on previous findings, and examines how individual-level subjective dispositions and human resources affect donor choice and the amount donated across eight different causes.

We find that while human resources are significant predictors for both donors’ likelihood to give and the amount donated among causes, subjective dispositions such as Empathic Concern may only predict donors’ incidence to give, but not the amount donated to any of the causes analyzed. This refers to the low-cost hypothesis, stating that individual attitudes and values do not predict behaviors when substantial costs are involved. Moreover, our research corroborates a findings of prior studies, namely that human resources mediate the impact of subjective dispositions on donor choice.

This study also explains why certain findings differ from studies undertaken with data from North America or UK. We find that in a representative, random sample, the mechanisms at work are those typical for a welfare-mix in continental Europe. For example, findings such as income not being related to donor choice for Art and Education might be due to the political context. Public funding for arts and culture and education in Austria is very different than in the USA or UK, where there are long-standing traditions of support for higher education that is private and alumni-supported. Thus, the generalizability of the findings to other countries with a different welfare-mix is limited.

Our study has limitations. We did not consider tax effects for charitable giving on donors’ choice. From prior literature, we know that tax deductions affect the level of contribution by way of price and income effects (Peloza and Steel 2005). Since the incentive was introduced in Austria only in 2009 for certain causes (Schober et al. 2015), and the data looked at donations made in 2010, it is likely that donor decisions were not made on the basis of this law. Future studies on donor choice need to examine

the impact of tax incentives, as they are only granted for donations to particular causes.

Furthermore, our finding that being asked to donate has the highest explanatory power regarding the incidence of giving among all causes investigated has to be interpreted with caution. An obvious difficulty here is that solicitation may also be a consequence of prior donations to this organization. While most studies do not take this endogeneity effect into account (e.g., Forbes and Zampelli 2011), Yörük’s (2007) study controlled for it; he found that solicitations still explain an increase in the likelihood and the amount of giving.

Further research on charitable giving and particularly on donor choice should particularly address the interaction of different predictors, for example resources, attitudes and values. Also, revisiting the low-cost hypothesis in research on charitable behavior is much needed. The alignment of the cause of the solicitation and the donor’s values need to be made to understand who is willing to undertake a high-cost measure of donating generously. Finally, with regard to solicitation, it is necessary to untangle whether it was the opportunity (being made aware of the cause) or the social pressure to which donors are responding, as both factors may interact to produce generous donors.

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